FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

When the BJP high command anointed the mahant of the Gorakhnath Math as the chief minister of Uttar Pradesh on March 19, 2017, after the party swept an assembly election it went into without naming a chief ministerial face, it came as a big surprise to the nattering nabobs who love speculating on such matters. In that election, the BJP won 312 of the state's 403 seats, the biggest win since Indira Gandhi's 309-seat haul in 1980. That election was won solely on the strength of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's charisma despite the demonetisation-induced distress just six months earlier threatening to damage the BJP's prospects. The landslide victory gave the party a free hand to appoint anyone of its choosing as the CM. Although the choice of Yogi Adityanath may have seemed a curious one, and the Gorakhnath Math mahant looked an outlier in Indian politics, appearances were deceptive. Yogi, 49, was no stranger to politics. A seasoned politician, he was the youngest Lok Sabha MP in 1998 and had represented Gorakhpur five consecutive times by 2014. After five years in office, he is still younger than when Narendra Modi took over as the chief minister of Gujarat at age 51. The responsibilities on Yogi's shoulders are far greater. An encore in UP will validate the party's model of good governance and Hindutva. And given that 2017 was the last major state election the BJP won decisively, a big win will help the party build the momentum that will perhaps see it through the other critical state elections. It also requires MLAs to shore up its numbers in the Rajya Sabha ahead of the presidential election mid-2022. UP thus is mission critical for the party and its election-fighting strategy.



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The electoral frenzy in India has already begun and will last until the 2024 Lok Sabha election. Sixteen, or more than half, of India's states will go to polls between now and May 2024. The most electorally significant of them is UP, one of five states where the first round of polling begins on February 10. With 80 Lok Sabha seats and 403 legislators who elect 31 Rajya Sabha MPs, the state is the beating heart of India's parliamentary democracy. Nine of India's 15 prime ministers were elected to the Lok Sabha from here. It has been the ground zero of two of India's biggest political movements in recent history—the Mandir agitation that heralded the rise of the BJP, and the Mandal stir that propelled the rise of caste-based parties like the Bahujan Samaj Party and Samajwadi Party. Whichever party controls the state, it can be safely said, directs the trajectory of Indian politics. No one knows this better than Prime Minister Modi and his home minister Amit Shah. The Ayodhya movement catapulted the BJP from a two-seat party in 1984 to a 120-seat one in 1991. In 2014, Modi contested the Lok Sabha election from Varanasi while Shah was the state party in-charge. The BJP won a remarkable 71 of the state's 80 seats, or 25 per cent of the overall 282 seats it won. The tally came down somewhat in 2019, to 62 seats in UP, but was still 20 per cent of the BJP's 303-seat score.

This time, the party is using the Ram temple construction and Kashi redevelopment project to push Hindutva among its core constituents. The chief minister's statement that this will be an "80 versus 20" election is being construed as an attempt to polarise voters—a charge he denies.

The BJP's electoral narrative pitches a Yogi-Modi 'double engine model' of economic development espoused by two charismatic leaders working in sync. They continue to rely on their strategy of aggressive welfarism that includes giving free food grains during the pandemic, providing affordable housing, paying massive arrears to farmers and myriad other schemes targeting the poor. And where there are elections, caste calculations cannot be far behind, especially in UP. The BJP has worked assiduously to broaden its traditional Brahmin-Bania base to woo other backward classes like the Nishads. It has attempted to nurture leaders from the extremely backward classes and allied with two minor caste-based parties.

Ranged against Yogi are some equally colourful contestants—political dynasts Akhilesh Yadav, Jayant Chaudhary and Priyanka Gandhi, and one inheritor, BSP chief Mayawati. Akhilesh, though, remains the biggest challenger as he seems to have converted an apparently multi-polar contest into a binary battle. The SP scion, only the second CM to complete a full term in office, had fought the 2017 election jointly with the Congress. In the 2019 general election, he added BSP to the alliance. He failed both times. Akhilesh's rebooted strategy this time sees him going solo, allying only with Jayant Chaudhary's Rashtriya Lok Dal in Jat-dominated western UP. He can count on the Muslim-Yadav vote that helped his father Mulayam rule the state for three non-consecutive terms. Muslims make up 20 per cent of the state's population, so even half these numbers could help him win. He stunned the BJP by luring three significant OBC leaders. He, too, is playing the caste game—expanding his traditional vote banks by allying with six smaller parties. The fact that the Election Commission has banned rallies for three weeks and may extend it could work in Akhilesh's favour, as it denies the BJP its biggest weapon—the Modi rally.

The pandemic hasn't helped Yogi either. Development has come to a standstill, and the state economy hit hard. The government is battling anti-incumbency and hard-to-forget visuals of the Covid dead floating down the Ganga last year. What may initially have seemed a cakewalk for Yogi and the BJP now looks an uphill climb. Our cover story, 'Can Yogi Make History?', by Group Editorial Director (Publishing) Raj Chengappa with Special Correspondent Prashant Srivastava, views this contest through the eyes of a man who is the fulcrum of the BJP's electoral strategy. If Yogi wins, he will make history and become the first UP CM since 1985 to be re-elected for a consecutive term.

An electoral victory could become a springboard for Yogi to leap into national politics. Yogi, go the whispers, could become a contender to replace Narendra Modi as PM in the not-so-distant future. Our Mood of the Nation 2022 poll, in fact, shows him neck-and-neck with home minister Shah as a likely successor to Modi. It remains to be seen how far this dark horse will go. Will he be the BJP's white knight? Like his anointment as chief minister five years ago, anything is possible in Indian politics.

(Aroon Purie)